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children will be able to sing with new meaning—"my country 'tis of thee; sweet land of liberty; of thee I sing; land where my fathers died, land of the pilgrim's pride; from every mountain side, let freedom ring"—and if America is to be a great nation, this must become true.

So let freedom ring from the prodigious hilltops of New Hampshire.

Let freedom ring from the mighty mountains of New York.

Let freedom ring from the heightening Alleghenies of Pennsylvania.

Let freedom ring from the snow-capped Rockies of Colorado.

Let freedom ring from the curvaceous slopes of California.

But not only that.

Let freedom ring from Stone Mountain of Georgia.

Let freedom ring from Lookout Mountain of Tennessee.

Let freedom ring from every hill and molehill of Mississippi, from every mountainside, let freedom ring.

And when we allow freedom to ring, when we let it ring from every village and hamlet, from every state and city, we will be able to speed up that day when all of God's children—black men and white men, Jews and Gentiles, Catholics and Protestants—will be able to join hands and to sing in the words of the old Negro spiritual, "Free at last, free at last; thank God Almighty, we are free at last."

## I've Been to the Mountaintop[1]•

Thank you very kindly, my friends. As I listened to Ralph Abernathy[2] in his eloquent and generous introduction and then thought about myself, I wondered who he was talking about. It's always good to have your closest friend and associate say something good about you. And Ralph is the best friend that I have in the world.

I'm delighted to see each of you here tonight in spite of a storm warning. You reveal that you are determined to go on anyhow. Something is happening in Memphis, something is happening in our world.

You know, if I were standing at the beginning of time, with the possibility of general and panoramic view of the whole human history up to now, and the Almighty said to me, "Martin Luther King, which age would you like to live in?"—I would take my mental flight by Egypt through, or rather across the Red Sea, through the wilderness on toward the promised land. And in spite of its magnificence, I wouldn't stop there. I would move on by Greece, and take my mind to Mount Olympus. And I would see Plato, Aristotle, Socrates, Euripides and Aristophanes assembled around the Parthenon as they discussed the great and eternal issues of reality.

But I wouldn't stop there. I would go on, even to the great heyday of the Roman Empire. And I would see developments around there, through various emperors and leaders. But I wouldn't stop there. I would even come up to the day of the Renaissance, and get a quick picture of all that the Renais-

1. King delivered this sermon, his last, on April 3, 1968, at the Bishop Charles Mason Temple in Memphis, Tennessee, on behalf of the city's largely black body of sanitation workers, who were pressing for higher wages and an end to maltreatment by white supervisors. King was assassinated on the following day.

2. Civil rights leader (1926–1990).

sance did for the cultural and esthetic life of man. But I wouldn't stop there. I would even go by the way that the man for whom I'm named had his habitat. And I would watch Martin Luther as he tacked his ninety-five theses on the door at the church in Wittenberg.

But I wouldn't stop there. I would come on up even to 1863, and watch a vacillating president by the name of Abraham Lincoln finally come to the conclusion that he had to sign the Emancipation Proclamation. But I wouldn't stop there. I would even come up to the early thirties, and see a man grappling with the problems of the bankruptcy of his nation. And come with an eloquent cry that we have nothing to fear but fear itself.

But I wouldn't stop there. Strangely enough, I would turn to the Almighty, and say, "If you allow me to live just a few years in the second half of the twentieth century, I will be happy." Now that's a strange statement to make, because the world is all messed up. The nation is sick. Trouble is in the land. Confusion all around. That's a strange statement. But I know, somehow, that only when it is dark enough, can you see the stars. And I see God working in this period of the twentieth century in a way that men, in some strange way, are responding—something is happening in our world. The masses of people are rising up. And wherever they are assembled today, whether they are in Johannesburg, South Africa: Nairobi, Kenya; Accra, Ghana; New York City; Atlanta, Georgia; Jackson, Mississippi; or Memphis, Tennessee—the cry is always the same—"We want to be free."

And another reason that I'm happy to live in this period is that we have been forced to a point where we're going to have to grapple with the problems that men have been trying to grapple with through history, but the demands didn't force them to do it. Survival demands that we grapple with them. Men, for years now, have been talking about war and peace. But now, no longer can they just talk about it. It is no longer a choice between violence and nonviolence in this world; it's nonviolence or nonexistence.

That is where we are today. And also in the human rights revolution, if something isn't done, and in a hurry, to bring the colored peoples of the world out of their long years of poverty, their long years of hurt and neglect, the whole world is doomed. Now, I'm just happy that God has allowed me to live in this period, to see what is unfolding. And I'm happy that he's allowed me to be in Memphis.

I can remember, I can remember when Negroes were just going around as Ralph has said, so often, scratching where they didn't itch, and laughing when they were not tickled. But that day is all over. We mean business now, and we are determined to gain our rightful place in God's world.

And that's all this whole thing is about. We aren't engaged in any negative protest and in any negative arguments with anybody. We are saying that we are determined to be men. We are determined to be people. We are saying that we are God's children. And that we don't have to live like we are forced to live.

Now, what does all of this mean in this great period of history? It means that we've got to stay together. We've got to stay together and maintain unity. You know, whenever Pharaoh wanted to prolong the period of slavery in Egypt, he had a favorite, favorite formula for doing it. What was that? He kept the slaves fighting among themselves. But whenever the slaves get together, something happens in Pharaoh's court, and he cannot hold the

slaves in slavery. When the slaves get together, that's the beginning of getting out of slavery. Now let us maintain unity.

Secondly, let us keep the issues where they are. The issue is injustice. The issue is the refusal of Memphis to be fair and honest in its dealings with its public servants, who happen to be sanitation workers. Now, we've got to keep attention on that. That's always the problem with a little violence. You know what happened the other day, and the press dealt only with the window-breaking. I read the articles. They very seldom got around to mentioning the fact that one thousand, three hundred sanitation workers were on strike, and that Memphis is not being fair to them, and that Mayor Loeb[3] is in dire need of a doctor. They didn't get around to that.

Now we're going to march again, and we've got to march again, in order to put the issue where it is supposed to be. And force everybody to see that there are thirteen hundred of God's children here suffering, sometimes going hungry, going through dark and dreary nights wondering how this thing is going to come out. That's the issue. And we've got to say to the nation: we know it's coming out. For when people get caught up with that which is right and they are willing to sacrifice for it, there is no stopping point short of victory.

We aren't going to let any mace stop us. We are masters in our nonviolent movement in disarming police forces; they don't know what to do. I've seen them so often. I remember in Birmingham, Alabama, when we were in that majestic struggle there we would move out of the 16th Street Baptist Church day after day; by the hundreds we would move out. And Bull Connor[4] would tell them to send the dogs forth and they did come; but we just went before the dogs singing, "Ain't gonna let nobody turn me round." Bull Connor next would say, "Turn the fire hoses on." And as I said to you the other night, Bull Connor didn't know history. He knew a kind of physics that somehow didn't relate to the transphysics that we knew about. And that was the fact that there was a certain kind of fire that no water could put out. And we went before the fire hoses; we had known water. If we were Baptist or some other denomination, we had been immersed. If we were Methodist, and some others, we had been sprinkled, but we knew water.

That couldn't stop us. And we just went on before the dogs and we would look at them; and we'd go on before the water hoses and we would look at it, and we'd just go on singing "Over my head I see freedom in the air." And then we would be thrown in the paddy wagons, and sometimes we were stacked in there like sardines in a can. And they would throw us in, and old Bull would say, "Take them off," and they did; and we would just go in the paddy wagon singing, "We Shall Overcome." And every now and then we'd get in the jail, and we'd see the jailers looking through the windows being moved by our prayers, and being moved by our words and our songs. And there was a power there which Bull Connor couldn't adjust to: and so we ended up transforming Bull into a steer, and we won our struggle in Birmingham.

Now we've got to go on in Memphis just like that. I call upon you to be with us Monday. Now about injunctions: We have an injunction and we're going into court tomorrow morning to fight this illegal, unconstitutional injunction. All we say to America is, "Be true to what you said on paper." If

3. Henry Loeb, mayor of Memphis (1960–63, 1968–71).
4. Eugene "Bull" Connor, Birmingham's commissioner of public safety, who repeatedly tangled with civil rights workers during demonstrations and marches.

I lived in China or even Russia, or any totalitarian country, maybe I could understand the denial of certain basic First Amendment privileges, because they hadn't committed themselves to that over there. But somewhere I read of the freedom of assembly. Somewhere I read of the freedom of speech. Somewhere I read of the freedom of the press. Somewhere I read that the greatness of America is the right to protest for right. And so just as I say, we aren't going to let any injunction turn us around. We are going on. We need all of you. And you know what's beautiful to me, is to see all of these ministers of the Gospel. It's a marvelous picture. Who is it that is supposed to articulate the longings and aspirations of the people more than the preacher? Somehow the preacher must be an Amos, and say, "Let justice roll down like waters and righteousness like a mighty stream." Somehow, the preacher must say with Jesus, "The spirit of the Lord is upon me, because he hath anointed me to deal with the problems of the poor."

And I want to commend the preachers, under the leadership of these noble men: James Lawson, one who has been in this struggle for many years; he's been to jail for struggling, but he's still going on, fighting for the rights of his people. Rev. Ralph Jackson, Billy Kiles; I could just go right on down the list, but time will not permit. But I want to thank them all. And I want you to thank them, because so often, preachers aren't concerned about anything but themselves. And I'm always happy to see a relevant ministry.

It's alright to talk about "long white robes over yonder," in all of its symbolism. But ultimately people want some suits and dresses and shoes to wear down here. It's alright to talk about "streets flowing with milk and honey," but God has commanded us to be concerned about the slums down here, and his children who can't eat three square meals a day. It's alright to talk about the new Jerusalem, but one day, God's preacher must talk about the New York, the new Atlanta, the new Philadelphia, the new Los Angeles, the new Memphis, Tennessee. This is what we have to do.

Now the other thing we'll have to do is this: Always anchor our external direct action with the power of economic withdrawal. Now, we are poor people, individually, we are poor when you compare us with white society in America. We are poor. Never stop and forget that collectively, that means all of us together, collectively we are richer than all the nations in the world, with the exception of nine. Did you ever think about that? After you leave the United States, Soviet Russia, Great Britain, West Germany, France, and I could name the others, the Negro collectively is richer than most nations of the world. We have an annual income of more than thirty billion dollars a year, which is more than all of the exports of the United States, and more than the national budget of Canada. Did you know that? That's power right there, if we know how to pool it.

We don't have to argue with anybody. We don't have to curse and go around acting bad with our words. We don't need any bricks and bottles, we don't need any Molotov cocktails, we just need to go around to these stores, and to these massive industries in our country, and say, "God sent us by here, to say to you that you're not treating his children right. And we've come by here to ask you to make the first item on your agenda—fair treatment, where God's children are concerned. Now, if you are not prepared to do that, we do have an agenda that we must follow. And our agenda calls for withdrawing economic support from you."

And so, as a result of this, we are asking you tonight, to go out and tell your neighbors not to buy Coca-Cola in Memphis. Go by and tell them not

to buy Sealtest milk. Tell them not to buy—what is the other bread?—Wonder Bread. And what is the other bread company, Jesse? Tell them not to buy Hart's bread. As Jesse Jackson has said, up to now, only the garbage men have been feeling pain; now we must kind of redistribute the pain. We are choosing these companies because they haven't been fair in their hiring policies; and we are choosing them because they can begin the process of saying, they are going to support the needs and the rights of these men who are on strike. And then they can move on downtown and tell Mayor Loeb to do what is right.

But not only that, we've got to strengthen black institutions. I call upon you to take your money out of the banks downtown and deposit your money in Tri-State Bank—we want a "bank-in" movement in Memphis. So go by the savings and loan association. I'm not asking you something that we don't do ourselves at SCLC. Judge Hooks and others will tell you that we have an account here in the savings and loan association from the Southern Christian Leadership Conference. We're just telling you to follow what we're doing. Put your money there. You have six or seven black insurance companies in Memphis. Take out your insurance there. We want to have an "insurance-in."

Now these are some practical things we can do. We begin the process of building a greater economic base. And at the same time, we are putting pressure where it really hurts. I ask you to follow through here.

Now, let me say as I move to my conclusion that we've got to give ourselves to this struggle until the end. Nothing would be more tragic than to stop at this point, in Memphis. We've got to see it through. And when we have our march, you need to be there. Be concerned about your brother. You may not be on strike. But either we go up together, or we go down together.

Let us develop a kind of dangerous unselfishness. One day a man came to Jesus; and he wanted to raise some questions about some vital matters in life. At points, he wanted to trick Jesus, and show him that he knew a little more than Jesus knew and through this, throw him off base. Now that question could have easily ended up in a philosophical and theological debate. But Jesus immediately pulled that question from mid-air, and placed it on a dangerous curve between Jerusalem and Jericho. And he talked about a certain man, who fell among thieves. You remember that a Levite and a priest passed by on the other side. They didn't stop to help him. And finally a man of another race came by. He got down from his beast, decided not to be compassionate by proxy. But with him, administered first aid, and helped the man in need. Jesus ended up saying, this was the good man, this was the great man, because he had the capacity to project the "I" into the "thou," and to be concerned about his brother. Now you know, we use our imagination a great deal to try to determine why the priest and the Levite didn't stop. At times we say they were busy going to a church meeting—an ecclesiastical gathering—and they had to get on down to Jerusalem so they wouldn't be late for their meeting. At other times we would speculate that there was a religious law that "One who was engaged in religious ceremonials was not to touch a human body twenty-four hours before the ceremony." And every now and then we begin to wonder whether maybe they were not going down to Jerusalem, or down to Jericho, rather to organize a "Jericho Road Improvement Association." That's a possibility. Maybe they felt that it was better to deal with the prob-

lem from the causal root, rather than to get bogged down with an individual effort.

But I'm going to tell you what my imagination tells me. It's possible that these men were afraid. You see, the Jericho road is a dangerous road. I remember when Mrs. King and I were first in Jerusalem. We rented a car and drove from Jerusalem down to Jericho. And as soon as we got on that road, I said to my wife, "I can see why Jesus used this as a setting for his parable." It's a winding, meandering road. It's really conducive for ambushing. You start out in Jerusalem, which is about 1200 miles, or rather 1200 feet above sea level. And by the time you get down to Jericho, fifteen or twenty minutes later, you're about 2200 feet below sea level. That's a dangerous road. In the days of Jesus it came to be known as the "Bloody Pass." And you know, it's possible that the priest and the Levite looked over that man on the ground and wondered if the robbers were still around. Or it's possible that they felt that the man on the ground was merely faking. And he was acting like he had been robbed and hurt, in order to seize them over there, lure them there for quick and easy seizure. And so the first question that the Levite asked was, "If I stop to help this man, what will happen to me?" But then the Good Samaritan came by. And he reversed the question: "If I do not stop to help this man, what will happen to him?"

That's the question before you tonight. Not, "If I stop to help the sanitation workers, what will happen to all of the hours that I usually spend in my office every day and every week as a pastor?" The question is not, "If I stop to help this man in need, what will happen to me?" "If I do not stop to help the sanitation workers, what will happen to them?" That's the question.

Let us rise up tonight with a greater readiness. Let us stand with a greater determination. And let us move on in these powerful days, these days of challenge to make America what it ought to be. We have an opportunity to make America a better nation. And I want to thank God, once more, for allowing me to be here with you.

You know, several years ago, I was in New York City autographing the first book that I had written. And while sitting there autographing books, a demented black woman came up. The only question I heard from her was, "Are you Martin Luther King?"

And I was looking down writing, and I said yes. And the next minute I felt something beating on my chest. Before I knew it I had been stabbed by this demented woman. I was rushed to Harlem Hospital. It was a dark Saturday afternoon. And that blade had gone through, and the X-rays revealed that the tip of the blade was on the edge of my aorta, the main artery. And once that's punctured, you drown in your own blood—that's the end of you.

It came out in the *New York Times* the next morning, that if I had sneezed, I would have died. Well, about four days later, they allowed me, after the operation, after my chest had been opened, and the blade had been taken out, to move around in the wheel chair in the hospital. They allowed me to read some of the mail that came in, and from all over the states, and the world, kind letters came in. I read a few, but one of them I will never forget. I had received one from the President and the Vice-President. I've forgotten what those telegrams said. I'd received a visit and a letter from the Governor of New York, but I've forgotten what the letter said. But there was another letter that came from a little girl, a young girl who was a student at the White Plains High School. And I looked at that letter, and I'll never forget it. It said simply, "Dear Dr. King: I am a ninth-grade

student at the White Plains High School." She said, "While it should not matter, I would like to mention that I am a white girl. I read in the paper of your misfortune, and of your suffering. And I read that if you had sneezed, you would have died. And I'm simply writing you to say that I'm so happy that you didn't sneeze."

And I want to say tonight, I want to say that I am happy that I didn't sneeze. Because if I had sneezed, I wouldn't have been around here in 1960, when students all over the South started sitting-in at lunch counters. And I knew that as they were sitting in, they were really standing up for the best in the American dream. And taking the whole nation back to those great walls of democracy which were dug deep by the Founding Fathers in the Declaration of Independence and the Constitution. If I had sneezed, I wouldn't have been around in 1962, when Negroes in Albany, Georgia, decided to straighten their backs up. And whenever men and women straighten their backs up, they are going somewhere, because a man can't ride your back unless it is bent. If I had sneezed, I wouldn't have been here in 1963, when the black people of Birmingham, Alabama, aroused the conscience of this nation, and brought into being the Civil Rights Bill. If I had sneezed, I wouldn't have had a chance later that year, in August, to try to tell America about a dream that I had had. If I had sneezed, I wouldn't have been down in Selma, Alabama, to see the great movement there. If I had sneezed, I wouldn't have been in Memphis to see a community rally around those brothers and sisters who are suffering. I'm so happy that I didn't sneeze.

And they were telling me, now it doesn't matter now. It really doesn't matter what happens now. I left Atlanta this morning, and as we got started on the plane, there were six of us, the pilot said over the public address system, "We are sorry for the delay, but we have Dr. Martin Luther King on the plane. And to be sure that all of the bags were checked, and to be sure that nothing would be wrong with the plane, we had to check out everything carefully. And we've had the plane protected and guarded all night."

And then I got into Memphis. And some began to say the threats, or talk about the threats that were out. What would happen to me from some of our sick white brothers?

Well, I don't know what will happen now. We've got some difficult days ahead. But it doesn't matter with me now. Because I've been to the mountaintop. And I don't mind. Like anybody, I would like to live a long life. Longevity has its place. But I'm not concerned about that now. I just want to do God's will. And He's allowed me to go up to the mountain. And I've looked over. And I've seen the promised land. I may not get there with you. But I want you to know tonight, that we, as a people, will get to the promised land. And I'm happy, tonight. I'm not worried about anything. I'm not fearing any man. Mine eyes have seen the glory of the coming of the Lord.

# MALCOLM X

## The Ballot or the Bullet[1]•

Brothers and sisters and friends, and I see some enemies.

In fact I think we'd be fooling ourselves if we had an audience this large and didn't realize that there were some enemies present.

This afternoon, we want to talk about *The Ballot or the Bullet. The Ballot or the Bullet* explains itself. But before we get into it, since this is the year of the ballot or the bullet, I would like to clarify some things that refer to me, personally, concerning my own personal position. I'm still a Muslim, that is my religion is still Islam.

My religion is still Islam. I still credit Mr. Muhammad for what I know and what I am. He's the one who opened my eyes. At present I am the minister of the newly founded Muslim Mosque Incorporated, which has its offices in the Theresa Hotel, right in that heart of Harlem—that's the black belt in New York City. And when we realize that Adam Clayton Powell[2] is a Christian minister, he heads the Abyssinian Baptist Church, but at the same time, he's more famous for his political struggling. And Dr. King[3] is a Christian minister from Atlanta, Georgia—or in Atlanta, Georgia—but he's become more famous for being involved in the Civil Rights struggle. The same as they are Christian ministers, I'm a Muslim minister. And I don't believe in fighting today in any one front, but on all fronts.

In fact I'm a black nationalist freedom fighter.

Islam is my religion, but I believe my religion is my personal business. It governs my personal life and my personal morals. And my religious philosophy is personal between me and the God in whom I believe—just as the religious philosophy of these others is between them and the God in whom they believe. And this is best this way. Were we to come out here discussing religion, we'd have too many differences from the out-start, and we could never get together. So today, though Islam is my religious philosophy, my political, economic, and social philosophy is black nationalism. As I say, if we bring up religion, we'll have differences, we'll have arguments, we'll never be able to get together. But if we keep our religion at home, keep our religion in the closet, keep our religion between ourselves and our God, but when we come out here, we have a fight that is common to all of us against an enemy who is common to all of us.

The political philosophy of black nationalism only means that the black man should control the politics and the politicians in his own community. The time when white people can come in our community, and get us to vote for them so that they can be our political leaders and tell us what to do and what not to do is long gone. Those days are gone. By the same token, the

1. After his break with Black Muslim leader Elijah Muhammad in 1964, Malcolm X (1925–1965) spoke with more forthrightness about politics in the United States. That year, he delivered versions of this speech many times, in New York, Cleveland, and Detroit. He gave this particular version in Detroit on April 14, 1964, at a rally sponsored by the Group on Advanced Leadership (GOAL).

2. Congressional representative from New York (1945–70).

3. Martin Luther King Jr.

time when that same white man, knowing that your eyes are too far open, can send another Negro into the community and get you and me to support him, so he can use him to lead us astray, those days are long gone, too.

The political philosophy of black nationalism only means that if you and I are going to live in a black community—and that's where we're going to live, 'cause soon as you move out of the black community into their community it's mixed for a period of time, but they're gone and you're right there by yourself again.

We must, we must understand the politics of our community. And we must know what politics is supposed to produce. We must know what part politics play in our lives. And until we become politically mature, we will always be misled, led astray, or deceived, or maneuvered into supporting someone politically who doesn't have the good of our community at heart.

So the political philosophy of black nationalism only means that we will have to carry on a program, a political program, of re-education, to open our people's eyes, make us become more politically conscious, politically mature. And then whenever we get ready to cast our ballot, that ballot will be cast for a man of the community who has the good of the community at heart.

The economic philosophy of black nationalism only means that we should own and operate and control the economy of our community. You can't open up a black store in a white community; the white man won't even patronize you. And he's not wrong, he's got sense enough to look out for himself. It's you, it's you who don't have sense enough to look out for yourself.

The white man is too intelligent to let someone else come and gain control of the economy of his community. But you will let anybody come in and control the economy of your community—control the housing, control the education, control the jobs, control the businesses—under the pretext that you want to integrate. Naw, you're out of your mind.

The economic philosophy of black nationalism only means that we have to become involved in a program of re-education, to educate our people into the importance of knowing that when you spend your dollar out of the community in which you live, the community in which you spend your money becomes richer and richer. The community out of which you take your money becomes poorer and poorer. And because these Negroes who have been misled and misguided are breaking their necks to take their money and spend it with the man, the man is becoming richer and richer and you're becoming poorer and poorer. And then what happens? The community in which you live becomes a slum. It becomes a ghetto. The conditions become run down. And then you have the audacity to complain about poor housing in a run-down community. Why, you run it down yourself, when you take your dollar out.

And you and I are in a double trap because, not only do we lose by taking our money someplace else and spending it, when we try and spend it in *our own* community, we're trapped because we haven't had sense enough to set up stores and control the businesses of our community. The man who's controlling the stores in our community is a man who doesn't look like we do. He's a man who doesn't even live in the community. So you and I, even when we try and spend our money in the block where we live, or the area where we live, we're spending it with a man who when the sun goes down takes that basket full of money in another part of the town.

So we're trapped. Trapped. Double trapped. Triple trapped. Any way we go, we find that we're trapped. And any kind of solution that someone comes

up with is just another trap. But the economic philosophy of black nationalism shows our people the importance of setting up these little stores, and developing them and expanding them into larger operations. Woolworth didn't start out big like they are today. They started out with *a* dime store and expanded and expanded and then expanded until today, they're all over the country and all over the world and they're getting some of everybody's money. Now, this is what you and I—General Motors, the same way, didn't start out like it is. It started out like a little rat-race type operation, and it expanded and it expanded until today it is where it is right now. And you and I have to make a start. And the best place to start is right in the community where we live.

So our people not only have to be re-educated to the importance of supporting black business, but the black man himself has to be made aware of the importance of going into business. And once you and I go into business, we own and operate *at least* the businesses in our community, what we will be doing is developing a situation wherein we will actually be able to create employment for the people in the community. And once you can create some employment in the community where you live, it will eliminate the necessity of you and me having to act ignorantly and disgracefully, boycotting and picketing some cracker someplace else, trying to beg him for a job.

Anytime you have to rely upon your enemy for a job, you're in bad shape.

He is your enemy. You wouldn't be in this country if some enemy hadn't kidnapped you and brought you here.

On the other hand, some of you think you came here on the *Mayflower.*

So, as you can see, brothers and sisters, today, this afternoon, it's not our intention to discuss religion. We're going to forget religion. If we bring up religion, we'll be in an argument. And the best way to keep away from arguments and differences, as I said earlier . . . put your religion at home, in the closet. Keep it between you and your God. Because if it hasn't done anything more for you than it has, you need to forget it anyway.

Whether you are a Christian or a Muslim or a Nationalist, we all have the same problem. They don't hang you because you're a Baptist, they hang you 'cause you're black. They don't attack me because I'm a Muslim, they attack me 'cause I'm black. They attack all of us for the same reason. All of us catch hell from the same enemy. We're all in the same bag. In the same boat. We suffer political oppression. Economic exploitation. And social degradation. All of 'em from the same enemy. The government has failed us. You can't deny that. Anytime you're living in the twentieth century, and you're walking around here singing "We Shall Overcome," the government has failed us.

This is part of what's wrong with you. You do too much singing.

Today, it's time to stop singing and start swinging.

You can't sing up on freedom. But you can *swing* up on some freedom.

Cassius Clay[4] can sing. But singing didn't help him to become the heavyweight champion of the world. *Swinging* helped him become the heavyweight champion of the world.

So this government has failed us. The government itself has failed us. And the white liberals, who have been posing as our friends, have failed us. And once we see that all these other sources to which we've turned have

4. Heavyweight boxer who, in 1964, took the name Muhammad Ali.

failed, we stop turning to them and turn to ourselves. We need a self-help program. A do-it-yourself philosophy. A do-it-right-now philosophy. A it's-already-too-late philosophy. This is what you and I need to get with. And the only way we're going to solve our problem is with a self-help program. Before we can get a self-help program started, we have to have a self-help philosophy. Black nationalism is a self-help philosophy. What's so good about it, you can stay right in the church where you are and still take black nationalism as your philosophy. You can stay in any kind of civic organization that you belong to and still take black nationalism as your philosophy. You can be an atheist and still take black nationalism as your philosophy. This is a philosophy that eliminates the necessity for division and argument. Because if you are black, you should be thinking black. And if you're a black, and you're not thinking black at this late date, why, I'm sorry for you.

Once you change your philosophy, you change your thought pattern. Once you change your thought pattern, you change your attitude. Once you change your attitude, it changes your behavior pattern. And then you go on into some action. As long as you got a sit-down philosophy, you'll have a sit-down thought pattern. And as long as you think that old sit-down thought, you'll be in some kind of sit-down action. They'll have you sitting-in everywhere.

It's not so good to refer to what you're going to do as a sit-in. Then right there it castrates you. Right there it brings you down. What goes with it? Think of the image of someone sitting. An old woman can sit. An old man can sit. A chump can sit. A coward can sit. Anything can sit. For you and I have been *sitting* long enough and it's time today for you and I to be doing some *standing*. And some *fighting* to back that up.

When we look at other parts of this earth in which we live, we find that black, brown, red and yellow people in Africa and Asia are getting their independence. They're not getting it by singing "We Shall Overcome." No, they're getting it through *nationalism*. It is nationalism that brought about the independence of the people in Asia. Every nation in Asia gained its independence through the philosophy of nationalism. Every nation on the African continent that has gotten its independence brought it about through the philosophy of nationalism. And it will take *black* nationalism to bring about the freedom of twenty-two million Afro-Americans here in this country where we have suffered *colonialism* for the past four hundred years.

America is just as much a colonial power as England ever was. America is just as much a colonial power as France ever was. In fact, America is more so a colonial power than they. Because she's a hypocritical colonial power behind it. What do you call second class citizenship? Why, that's colonization. Second-class citizenship is nothing but twentieth-century slavery. How are you going to tell me you're a second-class citizen? They don't have second class citizenship in any other government on this earth. They just have slaves and people who are free. Well, this country is a hypocrite. They try and make you think they set you free by calling you a second class citizen. Naw, you're nothing but a twentieth-century slave.

Just as it took nationalism to remove colonialism from Asia and Africa, it'll take black nationalism today to remove colonialism from the backs and the minds of twenty-two million Afro-Americans here in this country. Looks like it might be the year of the ballot or the bullet.

Why does it look like it might be the year of the ballot or the bullet? Because Negroes have listened to the trickery and the lies and the false

promises of the white man now for too long. And they're fed up. They've become disenchanted. They've become disillusioned. They've become dissatisfied. And all of this has built up frustrations in the black community that makes the black community throughout America today more explosive than all of the atomic bombs the Russians can ever invent. Whenever you got a racial powder keg sitting in your lap, you're in more trouble than if you had an atomic power keg sitting in your lap. When a racial powder keg goes off, it doesn't care who it knocks out the way. Understand this: it's dangerous. Because what can the white man use, now, to fool us? After he put down that march on Washington, and you see all through that now. He tricked you, had you marching down to Washington. Yes, had you marching back and forth between the feet of a dead man named Lincoln and another dead man named George Washington, singing "We Shall Overcome."

He made a chump out of you. He made a fool out of you. He made you think you were going somewhere and you end up going nowhere but between Lincoln and Washington.

So today our people are disillusioned. They've become disenchanted. They've become dissatisfied. And in their frustrations they want action. You can see this young black man, this new generation, asking for the ballot or the bullet. That old Uncle Tom action is outdated. The young generation don't want to hear anything about "The odds are against us." What do we care about odds?

When this country here was first being founded, there were thirteen colonies. The whites were colonized. They were fed up with this taxation without representation. So some of them stood up and said "liberty or death." Well, I went to a white school over here in Mason, Michigan. The white man made the mistake of letting me read his history books. He made the mistake of teaching me that Patrick Henry[5] was a patriot. And George Washington—wasn't nothing non-violent about old Pat. Or George Washington. "Liberty or death" was what brought about the freedom of whites in this country from the English.

They didn't care about the odds. Why, they faced the wrath of the entire British Empire. And in those days, they used to say that the British Empire was so vast and so powerful that the sun would never set on it. This is how big it was. Yet these thirteen little scrawny states, tired of taxation without representation, tired of being exploited and oppressed and degraded, told that big British Empire, "liberty or death." And here you have twenty-two million Afro-Americans, black people today, catching more hell than Patrick Henry ever saw.

And I'm here to tell you, in case you don't know it, that you got a new, you got a new generation of black people in this country who don't care anything whatsoever about odds. They don't want to hear you old Uncle Tom handkerchief-heads talking about the odds. No.

This is a new generation. If they're going to draft these young black men and send them over to Korea or South Vietnam to face eight hundred million Chinese . . . if you're not afraid of those odds, you shouldn't be afraid of these odds.

Why does this loom to be such an explosive *political* year? Because this is the year of politics. This is the year when all of the white politicians are

5. American Revolutionary leader and orator (1736–1799), famous for his pronouncement "Give me liberty or give me death."

going to come into the Negro community. You've never seen them until election time. You can't find them until election time. They're going to come in with false promises. And as they make these false promises, they're going to feed our frustrations. And this will only serve to make matters worse. I'm no politician. I'm not even a student of politics. I'm not a Republican nor a Democrat, nor an American. And got sense enough to know it.

I'm one of the twenty-two million black *victims* of the Democrats. One of the twenty-two million black *victims* of the Republicans. And one of the twenty-two million black *victims* of Americanism.

And when I speak, I don't speak as a Democrat, or a Republican, nor an American. I speak as a *victim* of America's so-called democracy. You and I have never seen democracy; all we've seen is hypocrisy. When we open our eyes today and look around America, we see America not through the eyes of someone who has enjoyed the fruits of Americanism, we see America through the eyes of someone who has been the victim of Americanism. We don't see any American dream. We've experienced only the American nightmare.

We haven't benefited from America's democracy. We've only suffered from America's hypocrisy. And the generation that is coming up now can see it, and are not afraid to say it. If you go to jail, so what? If you're black, you were born in jail. In the North as well as the South. Stop talking about the South. Long as you're south of the Canadian border, you're South.

Don't call Governor Wallace a Dixie governor; *Romney*[6] is a Dixie governor.

Twenty-two million black victims of Americanism are waking up. And they're gaining a new political consciousness, becoming politically mature. And as they develop this political maturity, they are able to see the recent trends in these political elections. They see that the whites are so evenly divided that every time they vote, the race is so close, they have to go back and count the votes all over again. Which means that any block, any minority that has a block of votes that stick together is in a strategic position. Either way you go, that's who gets it. You're in a position to determine who'll go to the White House and who'll stay in the dog house.

You're the one who has that power. You can keep Johnson[7] in Washington, D.C. or you can send him back to his Texas cotton patch.

You're the one who sent Kennedy to Washington. You're the one who put the present Democratic administration in Washington, D.C. The whites were evenly divided. It was the fact that you threw 80 percent of your votes behind the Democrats that put the Democrats in the White House. When you see this, you can see that the Negro vote is the key factor. And despite the fact that you are in a position to be the determining factor, what do you get out of it? The Democrats have been in Washington, D.C., only because of the Negro vote. They've been down there four years. And there, all other legislation they wanted to bring up, they've brought it up and gotten it out of the way, and now they bring up you. And *now* they bring up you. You put them first and they put you last . . .'cause you're a chump . . . a political chump.

In Washington, D.C., in the House of Representatives, there are 257 who are Democrats. Only 177 are Republican. In the Senate there are 67 Demo-

6. George Romney, governor of Michigan (1963–69). George Wallace, segregationist governor of Alabama (1963–66, 1971–79).

7. Lyndon B. Johnson, U.S. president (1963–69).

crats. Only 33 are Republicans. The party that *you* backed controls two-thirds of the House of Representatives and the Senate. And *still* they can't keep their promise to you. 'Cause you're a chump.

Anytime you throw your weight behind a political party that controls two-thirds of the government, and that party can't keep the promise that it made to you during election time, and you're dumb enough to walk around continuing to identify yourself with that party, you're not only a chump but you're a traitor to your race.

And what kind of alibi do they come up with? They try and pass the buck to the Dixiecrats. Now, back during the days when you were blind, deaf, and dumb, ignorant, politically immature, naturally you went along with that. But today, as your eyes come open, and you develop political maturity, you're able to see and think for yourself. And you can see that a Dixiecrat is nothing but a Democrat . . . in disguise.

You look at the structure of the government that controls this country. It's controlled by sixteen senatorial committees and twenty congressional committees. Of the sixteen senatorial committees that run the government, ten of them are in the hands of southern segregationists. Of the twenty congressional committees that run the government, twelve of them are in the hands of southern segregationists. And they going to tell you and me that the South lost the war.

You today are in the hands of a government of segregationists: Racists, white supremacists . . . who belong to the Democratic Party but disguise themselves as Dixiecrats. A Dixiecrat is nothing but a Democrat. Whoever runs the Democrats is also the follower of the Dixiecrats. And the follower of all of them is sitting in the White House.

I say and I say it again: You got a president who's nothing but a southern segregationist. From the state of Texas. They'll lynch you in Texas as quick as they'll lynch you in Mississippi. Only, in Texas, they lynch you with a Texas accent; in Mississippi, they lynch you with a Mississippi accent.

And the first thing the cracker does when he comes in power, he takes all the Negro leaders and invites them for coffee. To show that he's all right. And those Uncle Toms can't pass up the coffee.

They come away from the coffee table, telling you and me that this man is all right. 'Cause he's from the South. And since he's from the South, he can deal with the South. Look at the logic that they're using. What about Eastland?[8] He's from the South. Make him the president. If Johnson is a good man 'cause he's from Texas, and being from Texas will enable him to deal with the South, Eastland can deal with the South better than Johnson.

Naw, I say, you've been misled. You've been had. You been took.

I was in Washington a couple weeks ago—while the senators were filibustering. And I noticed at the back of the Senate a huge map. And on this map, it showed the distribution of Negroes in America. And surprisingly, the same senators that were involved in the filibuster were from the states where there were the most Negroes. Why were they filibustering the civil rights legislation? Because the civil rights legislation is supposed to guarantee voting rights to Negroes in those states. And those senators from those states know that if the Negroes in those states can vote, those senators are down the drain.

8. James Eastland, U.S. senator from Mississippi (1943–78).

The representatives of those states go down the drain. And in the Constitution of this country, it has a stipulation wherein whenever the rights, the voting rights of people in a certain district are violated, then the representative who's from a particular district, according to the Constitution is supposed to be expelled from the Congress. Now, if this particular aspect of the Constitution was enforced, why you wouldn't have a cracker in Washington, D.C.

But what would happen? When you expel the Dixiecrat, you're expelling the Democrat. When you destroy the power of the Dixiecrat, you're destroying the power of the Democratic Party. So how in the world can the Democratic Party in the South actually side with you, in sincerity, when all of this power is based in the South? These northern Democrats are in cahoots with the southern Democrats.

They're playing a giant con game. A political con game. You know how it goes. Whenever one of them comes to you, and make believe he's for you. And he's in cahoots with the other one that's not for you. Why? Because neither one of them is for you. But they got to make you go with one of them or the other. So this is a con game. And this is what they been doing with you and me all these years. First thing Johnson got off the plane, when he became president, he asked, "Where's Dicky?" You know who "Dicky" is? Dicky is old southern cracker Richard Russell.[9] Look a-here! *Yes!* Lyndon B. Johnson's best friend is the one who is the head, who's heading the forces that are filibustering civil rights legislation. You tell me how in the hell is he going to be Johnson's best friend?

How can Johnson be his friend and your friend too? Naw, that man is too tricky. Especially if his friend is still old Dicky.

Whenever the Negroes keep the Democrats in power, they're keeping the Dixiecrats in power. Is this true? A vote for a Democrat is nothing but a vote for a Dixiecrat. I know you don't like me saying that. But I'm not the kind of person who'll come here to say what you like. I'm going to tell you the truth whether you like it or not.

Up here in the North, you have the same thing. The Democratic Party . . . they don't do it that way. They got a thing that they call gerrymandering. They maneuver you out of power. Even though you can vote, they fix it so you're voting for nobody.

They got you going and coming. In the South, they're outright political wolves. In the North they're political foxes. A fox and a wolf are both canine—both belong to the dog family. Now, you take your choice. You going to choose a northern dog or a southern dog? Because either dog you choose, I guarantee you, you'll still be in the doghouse.

This is why I say it's the ballot or the bullet. It's liberty or it's death. It's freedom for everybody or freedom for nobody.

America today finds herself in a unique situation. Historically, revolutions are bloody, oh yes they are. They haven't ever had a blood*less* revolution. Or a non-violent revolution. That don't happen even in Hollywood. You don't have a revolution in which you love your enemy. And you don't have a revolution in which you're begging the system of exploitation to integrate you into it. Revolutions overturn systems. Revolutions destroy systems. A revolution is bloody.

9. Governor of Georgia (1931–33), U.S. senator from Georgia (1932–71).

But America is in a unique position. She's the only country in history in a position actually to become involved in a bloodless revolution. The Russian revolution was bloody. The Chinese revolution was bloody. The French revolution was bloody. The Cuban revolution was bloody. And there was nothing more bloody than the American revolution. But today, this country can become involved in a revolution that won't take bloodshed. All she's got to do is give the black man in this country everything that's due him. Everything.

I hope that the white man can see this. 'Cause if you don't see it, you're finished. If you don't see it, you're going to become involved in some action in which you don't have a chance. And we don't care about your atomic bomb, it's useless. Because other countries have atomic bombs. When two or three different countries have atomic bombs, nobody can use it. So it means that the white man today is without a weapon. And if you want some action, you got to come on down to earth. And there's more black people on earth than there are white people on earth.

I only got a couple more minutes. The white man can never win another war on the ground. His days of war victory, his days of ground victory are over. Can I prove it? Yes. Take all the action that's going on on this earth, right now, that he's involved in. Tell me where he's winning. Nowhere. Why some rice farmers, some rice farmers, some rice eaters, ran him out of Korea. Yes, they ran him out of Korea. Rice eaters, with nothing but gym shoes and a rifle and a bowl of rice. Took him and his tanks and his napalm and all that other action he's supposed to have, and ran him 'cross the Yalu. Why? 'Cause the day that he can win on the ground is past. Up in French Indochina, those little peasants, rice growers, took on the might of the French army. And ran all the Frenchmen—you don't remember Dien Bien Phu???[1] Naw!!! The same thing happened in Algeria, in Africa. They didn't have anything but a rifle. The French had all these highly mechanized instruments of warfare. But they put some guerrilla action on 'em. And a white man can't fight a guerrilla war. Guerrilla action takes heart, takes nerve, and he doesn't have that.

He's brave when he's got tanks. He's brave when he's got planes. He's brave when he's got bombs. He's brave when he's got a whole lot of company along with him. But you take that little man from Africa and Asia, turn him loose in the woods with a blade, with a blade. That's all he needs, all he needs is a blade. And when the sun goes down, and it's dark, it's even-steven.

So it's the ballot or the bullet. Today our people can see that we're faced with a government conspiracy. This government has failed us. The senators who are filibustering concerning your and my rights—that's the government. Don't say it's southern senators. This is the *government*. This is the *government* filibuster. It's not a segregationist filibuster. It's the *government* filibuster. Any kind of activity that takes place on the floor of the Congress or the Senate, that's the government. Any kind of dilly-dallying, that's the government. Any kind of pussyfooting, that's the government. Any kind of act that's designed to delay or deprive you and me, right now, of getting full rights, that's the government that's responsible. And anytime you find the

1. The Vietnamese victory in the battle of Dien Bien Phu (1954) inspired the permanent withdrawal of the French from Indochina and the Geneva Accords of 1954.

government involved in a conspiracy, to violate the citizenship, or the civil rights of a people, then you are wasting your time going to that government expecting redress. Instead you have to take that government to the World Court and accuse it of genocide and all of the other crimes that it is guilty of today.

So those of us whose political and economic and social philosophy is black nationalism have become involved in the civil rights struggle, we have injected ourselves into the civil rights struggle, and we intend to expand it from the level of civil rights to the level of human rights. As long as you fight it on the level of civil rights, you're under Uncle Sam's jurisdiction. You're going to his court expecting him to correct the problem. He *created* the problem. He's the criminal. You don't take your case to the criminal. You take your criminal to court.

When the government of South Africa began to trample upon the human rights of the people of South Africa, they were taken to the U.N. When the government of Portugal began to trample upon the rights of our brothers and sisters in Angola, it was taken before the U.N. Why even the white man took the Hungarian question to the U.N. and just this week, Chief Justice Goldberg[2] was crying over three million Jews in Russia about their human rights, charging Russia with violating the U.N. charter, because of its mistreatment of the human rights of Jews in Russia. Now you tell me, how can the plight of everybody on this earth reach the halls of the United Nations, and you have twenty-two million Afro-Americans whose churches are being bombed? Whose little girls are being murdered. Whose leaders are being shot down in broad daylight. Now you tell me why the leaders of this struggle have never taken it before the United Nations.

So, our next move, is to take the entire civil rights struggle, problem, into the United Nations.

And let the world see that Uncle Sam is guilty of violating the human rights of twenty-two million Afro-Americans and still has the audacity or the nerve to stand up and to represent himself as the leader of the free world.

Not only is he a crook, he's a hypocrite. Here he is, standing up in front of other people, Uncle Sam, with the blood of your and my mothers and fathers on his hands. With the blood dripping down his jaws like a bloody-jawed wolf. And still got the nerve to point his finger at other countries. You can't even get civil rights legislation. And this man has got the nerve to stand up and talk about South Africa. Or talk about Nazi Germany. Or talk about Portugal. Naw, no more days like those.

So I say in my conclusion, the only way we're going to solve it, we got to unite, we got to work together in unity and harmony. And black nationalism is the key. How we going to overcome the tendency to be at each other's throats that always exists in our neighborhood? And the reason this tendency exists—the strategy of the white man has always been divide and conquer. He keeps us divided in order to conquer us. He tells you I'm for separation and you're for integration and keep us fighting with each other. No, I'm not for separation and you're not for integration. What you and I are for is freedom.

2. Arthur Joseph Goldberg, lawyer, associate Supreme Court justice (1962–65), U.S. representative to the United Nations (1965–68).

Only you think that integration will get you freedom, I think that separation will get me freedom. We both got the same objective. We just both got different ways of getting at it.

So, I studied this man Billy Graham,[3] who preaches white nationalism. That's what he preaches. I say, that's what he preaches. The whole church structure in this country is white nationalism. You go inside a white church, that's what they preaching, white nationalism. They got Jesus white, Mary white, God white, everybody white, that's white nationalism.

So, what he does, the way he circumvents the jealousy and envy that he ordinarily would incur among the heads of the church, whenever you go into an area where the church already is, you going to run into trouble. Because they got that thing, what you call it, syndicated, they got a syndicate, just like the racketeers have. I'm going to say what's on my mind, cause the church, the preachers have already proved to you that they got a syndicate.

And when you're out in the rackets, whenever you're getting in another man's territory, you know, they gang up on you. And that's the same way with you—you run into the same thing. So how Billy Graham gets around that, instead of going into somebody else's territory, like he going to start a new church, he doesn't try to start a church, he just goes in preaching Christ. And he says, everybody who believes in Him, you go wherever you find Him. So this helps all the churches, and so since it helps all the churches, they don't fight him. Well, we're going to do the same thing, only our gospel is black nationalism. His gospel is white nationalism, our gospel is black nationalism. And the gospel of black nationalism, as I told you, means you should control your own—the politics of your community, the economy of your community, and all of the society in which you live should be under your control. And once you feel that this philosophy will solve your problem, go join any church where that's preached. Don't join a church where white nationalism is preached. Now, you can go to a Negro church and be exposed to white nationalism. 'Cause when you walk in a Negro church and you see a white Jesus and a white Mary and some white angels, that Negro church is preaching white nationalism.

But when you go to a church and you see the pastor of that church with a philosophy and a program that's designed to bring black people together and elevate black people, join that church. Join that church. If you see where the NAACP is preaching and practicing that which is designed to make black nationalism materialize, join the NAACP. Join any kind of organization, civic, religious, fraternal, political, or otherwise, that's based on lifting the black man up and making him master of his own community.

It'll be the ballot or it'll be the bullet. It'll be liberty or it'll be death. And if you're not ready to pay that price, don't use the word freedom in your vocabulary.

One more thing: I was on the program in Illinois recently with Senator Paul Douglas[4] the so-called liberal, the so-called Democrat, the so-called white man. At which time he told me that our African brothers were not interested in us in Africa. He says the Africans are not interested in the American Negro. I knew he was lying. But, during the next two or three weeks, it's my intention and plan to make a tour of our African homeland.

3. American evangelist (b. 1918).

4. U.S. senator from Massachusetts (1948–66).

And I hope that when I come back I'll be able to come back and let you know how our African brothers and sisters feel toward us.

And I know before I go there, that they love us. We're one. We're the same. It's the same man that colonized them all these years that colonized you and me too, all these years. And all we have to do now is wake up and work in unity and harmony and the battle will be over.

I want to thank the Freedom Now Party in the gold; I want to thank Milton and Richard Henry for inviting me here this afternoon, and also a Reverend Cley. And I want them to know that anything that I can ever do at anytime to work with anybody in any kind of program that is sincerely designed to eliminate the political, the economic, and the social evils that confront all of our people in Detroit and elsewhere, all you've got to do is give me a telephone call, and I'll be on the next jet right on into the city.

Thank you.

# BERT WILLIAMS

## Elder Eatmore's Sermon on Generosity[1]•

I takes my text tonight from the book of *'Phesians:* "The Lord loveth a cheerful giver."[2] Tonight my friends, you can omit the "*cheerful.*" The truth is the light and here is the truth: Y'all is way back in my salary! And somethin' has got to be done here this evenin'. 'Cause if somethin' ain't done, your shepherd is gone. That's *all. That-is-all!!* I admit that times is tight. 'Cause when there used to be a ham coming here and a fowl or two from there from different members of this flock, I managed to make out fair to middlin'. They all come to heal weight, but you-all done learnt me that self-preservation is the first law of he who gets it! And the Lord helps them that helps theirself.

Everything's got so scientifical nowadays that they done commenced buildin' such things as smokehouses and henhouses out of pure concrete! And they's invented locks for 'em, the same as combinations on the First National Bank. True, true, that makes it harder for all of us. (It's pretty nigh ruint me.) And my friends, I needs, I *needs.* . . . T'ain't no use talkin' about *what* I needs, I needs *everything!* From a hat down and from an overcoat in.

T'ain't no use in getting restless, brother there now, now, now now now now, 'cause here is the program: We ain't gwine to pass no plate this evenin', y'all is comin' up one at a time. And drap your offerin's on this thing here whiles I's-a look down from the altar here with a eagle eye. We will start with the first row. Come, my lambs. Your shepherd calls unto you,

1. A parody of a sermon by Bert Williams; recorded in New York, June 1919 that underscores how, for some believers, humor can fortify religious conviction.

2. The line is actually from 2 Corinthians 9.7. "'Phesians": i.e., Ephesians.